

These keywords connect to a major geopolitical flashpoint covered by journalist and historian Anne Applebaum: the **November 25, 2018, Kerch Strait Incident** between Russia and Ukraine.

Here is how these three elements intertwine:

1. Anne

Applebaum's Washington Post Column

On November 26, 2018, Anne Applebaum published an op-ed in *The Washington Post* titled "**Russia's latest attack on the Ukrainians is a warning to the West.**" * **The Core Argument:** Applebaum argued that the naval clash was not an accident, but a calculated escalation by Vladimir Putin. She highlighted that a 2003 bilateral treaty guaranteed both nations open transit through the strait, making Russia's actions a flagrant breach of international law.

- **The Geopolitical Context:** She noted that the timing served multiple domestic purposes for the Kremlin—boosting Putin's falling popularity following deeply unpopular pension reforms, straining Ukraine's political climate ahead of their March 2019 presidential elections, and executing a "creeping blockade" to choke off the Ukrainian economy by restricting access to the major industrial ports of Mariupol and Berdyansk.

2. The Kerch

Strait Incident (November 25, 2018)

The incident occurred when a small Ukrainian naval flotilla—consisting of two small armored gunboats (*Berdyansk* and *Nikopol*) and a tugboat (*Yany Kapu*)—attempted to sail from the Black Sea port of Odesa through the narrow Kerch Strait into the Sea of Azov.

Russian FSB Coast Guard vessels aggressively intercepted them, rammed the Ukrainian tugboat, and physically blocked the shipping channel beneath the newly constructed Crimean Bridge by parking a massive commercial cargo ship transversely across it. After a tense, hours-long standoff, the Ukrainian ships attempted to turn back, but Russian forces pursued them into international waters, opened fire, injured several crew members, and captured all 24 Ukrainian sailors.

3. The Role of

the Su-25 Frogfoot

During the initial blockage and standoff at the bridge, Russia immediately escalated the confrontation by scrambling heavy military air support to patrol the skies and intimidate the trapped Ukrainian vessels.

Eyewitnesses and military logs confirmed that Russia deployed:

- **Ka-52 Alligator** attack helicopters.
- **Su-25 "Frogfoot"** twin-engine close-air-support jet aircraft, which were filmed flying low directly over the Kerch Strait Bridge to enforce the blockade.

Applebaum used this overt deployment of heavy conventional military assets (like the Su-25s and naval firing) to warn Western powers that Russia was testing their passivity. She accurately predicted that if the West responded with weak or delayed condemnation, Russia would continue utilizing the area to further its expansionist playbook in Ukraine.